

The Hybrid Trident: Strategic Convergence of Russian Maritime, Cyber, and Cognitive Warfare in the Anglophone and Francophone Spheres

Executive Summary

As the geopolitical landscape of early 2026 crystallizes, the security architecture of the Western alliance faces a sophisticated, multi-layered threat from the Russian Federation. This report, commissioned to provide an exhaustive analysis of Russian cybersecurity, maritime activity, and social media manipulation, identifies a unified strategic doctrine—the "Hybrid Trident"—that integrates physical sabotage, logical cyber disruption, and cognitive warfare. The analysis reveals that Russian operations are not isolated verticals but synchronized components of "New Generation Warfare." The physical mapping of undersea cables by the Main Directorate for Deep Sea Research (GUGI) in the Atlantic and Indian Oceans correlates with cyber-reconnaissance of critical infrastructure control systems by GRU Unit 29155. Simultaneously, industrial-scale disinformation campaigns, evolved from the legacy of Cambridge Analytica into automated networks like "Portal Kombat" and the "African Initiative," exploit the resulting societal anxieties.

A critical divergence is observed in the targeting of Anglophone and Francophone spheres. The Anglophone world (UK, US, Commonwealth) faces direct threats to the physical integrity of the internet backbone and "culture war" subversion, exacerbated by the recent institutional retraction of US counter-disinformation capabilities (the closure of the Global Engagement Center). Conversely, the Francophone world (France, Sahel, Overseas Territories) confronts a localized, highly aggressive hybrid war leveraging post-colonial grievances, where physical presence (naval port calls) supports cognitive narratives of "liberation," directly threatening French sovereignty in the Indo-Pacific.

1. Doctrinal Architecture: The Theoretical Basis of Hybrid Convergence

To comprehend the correlation between a fishing research vessel in Mauritania and a bot farm in St. Petersburg, one must first deconstruct the military doctrine that binds them. Russian strategic thought has moved beyond the binary of war and peace, embracing a continuous state of "information confrontation."

1.1 The Gerasimov Doctrine and New Generation Warfare

The intellectual foundation of current Russian operations is the "New Generation Warfare" (NGW) concept, often associated with General Valery Gerasimov. This doctrine posits that the "rules of war" have changed significantly, with non-military means—political, economic, and informational—exceeding the power of weapons in their effectiveness. The doctrine calls for a 4:1 ratio of non-military to military action, emphasizing the "importance of controlling the information space and the real-time coordination of all aspects of a campaign".¹

This framework views the "information space" as a total domain. It is not limited to media; it encompasses the *physical* infrastructure that carries information (cables), the *logical* code that directs it (cyber), and the *cognitive* minds that process it (psychology).

1.2 The Chekinov-Bogdanov Paradigm: The Initial Period of War

Military theorists Sergei Chekinov and Sergei Bogdanov have further refined this, arguing that the "Initial Period of War" (IPW) is decisive. They advocate for "asymmetric actions" to eradicate an enemy's superiority through "nonmilitary measures" before kinetic conflict begins. A key component of this is the "destruction of critical infrastructure" to induce psychological collapse and the "disorganization of military command and control".³

The doctrine explicitly links physical infrastructure attacks to cognitive effects. The destruction of fiber-optic cables is theorized not just as a logistical inconvenience, but as a mechanism to create "chaos in the work of governmental bodies" and spark a "social explosion".⁶ This effectively weaponizes the modern world's dependency on connectivity.

1.3 From Information War to Cognitive Warfare

By 2025, the operational focus has shifted from "Information Warfare" (controlling data flow) to "Cognitive Warfare" (controlling mental processing). NATO's Allied Command Transformation (ACT) and the StratCom Centre of Excellence define this as the "weaponization of public opinion" by an external actor.⁷

Russian strategy now employs a dual-pressure mechanism:

1. **Information Blockade (The Void):** The threat of severing undersea cables (CUI) creates a primal fear of isolation. Russian military journals discuss "cable severance" as a means to create an information blockade, forcing the adversary population into a state of uncertainty.⁹
2. **Information Flood (The Noise):** Simultaneously, the adversary is inundated with high-volume, automated disinformation (e.g., Portal Kombat) to destroy shared reality and trust in institutions.¹⁰

This combination aims to fracture the target society's will to resist. In the words of Chekinov and Bogdanov, the "main battlefield is consciousness, perception, and strategic calculus of the adversary".⁵

2. The Physical Domain: Maritime Hybrid Warfare and

Undersea Infrastructure

The physical integrity of the global internet relies on a fragile network of subsea fiber-optic cables. Russia has developed the world's most advanced specialized naval fleet dedicated to interfering with this infrastructure, operating under the Main Directorate for Deep Sea Research (GUGI).

2.1 The GUGI Fleet: Capabilities and Intent

GUGI is a distinct entity from the regular Russian Navy, reporting directly to the Ministry of Defense. It operates a "Ghost Fleet" of oceanographic research vessels and nuclear-powered specialized submarines (e.g., *Losharik*, *Belgorod*) designed for seabed warfare.

The *Yantar* Phenomenon: Mapping the Anglophone Arteries

The *Yantar* (Project 22010) is the most visible asset in this fleet. Officially an oceanographic research vessel, it is equipped with two deep-sea submersibles (*Rus* and *Consul*) capable of diving to 6,000 meters. Western intelligence agencies assess the *Yantar* is tasked with mapping CUI vulnerabilities, deploying seabed sensors, and preparing for cable severance.¹¹

The Irish Sea Campaign (2025):

In late 2025, the *Yantar* engaged in highly provocative maneuvers in the Irish Sea and North Sea. This region is a critical chokepoint, hosting the high-capacity cables linking the UK to the United States and Ireland (the EU headquarters for many US tech giants).

- **Incident Analysis:** The vessel was shadowed by the Royal Navy frigate *HMS Somerset* and RAF P-8 Poseidon maritime patrol aircraft. During this interaction, the *Yantar* reportedly directed laser dazzlers at the RAF pilots, a significant escalation in "grey zone" aggression intended to blind sensors and intimidate personnel.¹³
- **Strategic Intent:** The UK Defense Secretary confirmed the vessel was "mapping British undersea cables".¹⁵ This mapping is a prerequisite for sabotage; identifying the precise location of cables in deep water or underwater canyons allows for cuts that are difficult to repair.

2.2 The "Great African Expedition": The Southern Flank

While GUGI focuses on the North Atlantic, the Russian Federal Agency for Fisheries (VNIRO) launched the "Great African Expedition" (2024–2026). This involves two research vessels, *Atlantis* and *Atlantniro*, conducting surveys from Morocco to the Indian Ocean.¹⁶

Dual-Use Hydrography

While nominally assessing fish stocks (biomass), these vessels possess dual-use capabilities relevant to seabed warfare.

- **Capabilities:** *Atlantis* and *Atlantniro* are equipped with advanced acoustic suites and multi-beam echo sounders. This equipment, necessary for finding fish, also produces high-resolution bathymetric maps of the seafloor.¹⁷
- **Strategic Correlation:** The expedition route mirrors the path of critical West African

cable systems (ACE, WACS, Equiano) and Indian Ocean systems (SAFE, 2Africa).

- **Mauritania (Jan 2025):** The *Atlantis* docked in Nouadhibou, Mauritania, to conduct "bottom surveys".¹⁹ Mauritania is a key landing point for the ACE cable. Detailed bathymetric data of the approach to Nouadhibou provides Russia with the intelligence needed to interdict this cable covertly.
- **Indian Ocean:** The expedition is scheduled to move into the western Indian Ocean, operating in the EEZs of Mozambique, Madagascar, and Mauritius.²⁰ This brings Russian sensor platforms into the vicinity of the cables connecting East Africa to Asia and Europe.

2.3 Vulnerabilities in the French Indo-Pacific

France possesses the world's second-largest Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), largely due to its overseas territories. Russia has begun probing these peripheries, recognizing them as critical nodes in the global network that are harder to defend than the North Atlantic.

Reunion Island and Mayotte

Reunion Island is a "digital fortress" and a strategic hub for French naval power in the Indian Ocean. It hosts landing stations for the SAFE (South Africa Far East) and METISS cables.

- **Russian Activity:** Russian naval vessels and research ships have increased their presence in the Mozambique Channel. The "Great African Expedition" vessels are explicitly tasked with surveying the western Indian Ocean.¹⁶
- **Strategic Threat:** A disruption of the cables landing in Reunion would not only isolate the island but sever a primary data link between Asia and Africa. Russia's port calls in nearby friendly nations (Madagascar, Mozambique) provide logistical support for sustained loitering in the French EEZ.²¹

New Caledonia: The Vulnerability of Isolation

New Caledonia relies on the Gondwana-1 cable for connectivity. The 2024 riots demonstrated how political unrest is amplified by information warfare.

- **The Scenario:** A physical cable cut during a period of unrest would force the territory onto limited satellite bandwidth. This "information blockade" would create panic, degrade the local government's ability to communicate with Paris, and create a fertile environment for rumors—a textbook application of the Chekinov-Bogdanov doctrine.²³

2.4 The Anglophone Response: Atlantic Bastion

In response to the *Yantar* incursions and the sabotage of Baltic Sea cables (C-Lion1 in late 2024), the UK Ministry of Defence launched the "Atlantic Bastion" program.

- **Concept:** This initiative represents a shift from reactive policing to persistent area denial. It integrates autonomous surface vessels (ASVs), underwater drones, and RAF P-8 Poseidons to create a sensor net around critical undersea infrastructure.²⁴
- **Operationalization:** Slated for full deployment in 2026, the program acknowledges that the seabed is now a contested flank. It specifically aims to counter the capabilities of

vessels like *Yantar* by detecting them before they can deploy submersibles.²⁴

3. The Logical Domain: Cyber Offensive and Critical Infrastructure

While maritime assets threaten the physical cables, Russian cyber units target the data and control systems (OT/ICS) that run through them. The Russian cyber apparatus has bifurcated into highly specialized Advanced Persistent Threats (APTs) and state-encouraged "hacktivist" auxiliaries.

3.1 The GRU's Cyber-Kinetic Integration

The Main Intelligence Directorate (GRU) remains the apex actor in Russian offensive cyber operations.

- **Unit 29155:** Historically known for kinetic operations (assassinations, sabotage), intelligence assessments from 2024–2025 confirm that Unit 29155 has fully integrated offensive cyber capabilities.
 - **Mission:** Unlike traditional espionage units, 29155 is tasked with destructive operations. They have been linked to the "WhisperGate" wiper malware, designed to irrevocably destroy data rather than steal it.²⁶
 - **Targeting:** The unit targets critical infrastructure logistics and transport networks, aiming to disrupt the movement of aid and military materiel. This aligns with Gerasimov's goal of "disorganization of command and control".²⁶

3.2 The Rise of Proxy "Hacktivists"

To maintain plausible deniability and increase the volume of attacks, the GRU coordinates with hacktivist groups.

- **Cyber Army of Russia Reborn (CARR):** This group targets Operational Technology (OT) in US and European utilities. In late 2024, internal dissent led to a splinter group, **Z-Pentest**, which continues to employ the same tactics.²⁷
- **TTPs:** These groups target Human-Machine Interfaces (HMIs) in water and energy sectors. While less sophisticated than the GRU, their attacks create "noise" and panic, forcing defenders to expend resources on remediation. The targeting of US dairy farms (an agricultural critical sector) illustrates the breadth of this "total war" targeting philosophy.²⁷

3.3 Comparative Cyber Doctrines: US vs. France vs. Russia

Feature	Russian Doctrine (Information Confrontation)	US Doctrine (Persistent Engagement)	French Doctrine (Lutte Informatique Offensive)
Primary Goal	Destabilization &	Forward Defense &	Sovereign Autonomy &

	Cognitive Effect ²⁸	Network Resilience ²⁹	Active Response ³⁰
Key Capability	Unit 29155: Destructive malware (WhisperGate) integrated with sabotage. ²⁶	Hunt Forward Teams: Deploying to partner nations to harden networks. ³¹	LIO (Offensive Cyber): Doctrine allowing offensive strikes to neutralize attacks. ³²
Operational Concept	Total War: Cyber is one tool among many (disinfo, cable cuts).	"Defend Forward": Engage adversaries in foreign networks before they attack.	"Active Defense": Identifying and neutralizing the attacker's infrastructure.

3.4 US "Hunt Forward" in the Commonwealth

The US Cyber Command has actively deployed "Hunt Forward" teams to harden the networks of allies, directly countering Russian influence.

- **Zambia (Anglophone Africa):** A US team deployed to Zambia to assist the Zambia Information and Communications Technology Authority (ZICTA). This operation hardened Zambian networks against malign actors, securing a key democratic partner in Southern Africa. ³³
- **Croatia:** A similar deployment to Croatia (NATO/EU) hardened systems against Russian intrusion, demonstrating the US commitment to "persistent engagement" outside its borders. ³⁴

4. The Cognitive Domain: Industrialized Influence and Social Manipulation

The third prong of the Hybrid Trident is the manipulation of the information environment. Russian capabilities have evolved from the manual "troll farms" of 2016 to automated, AI-driven systems and psychographically targeted campaigns.

4.1 The Legacy of Cambridge Analytica

The revelation of Cambridge Analytica's (CA) activities exposed the power of psychographic targeting—using personality data to tailor political messaging.

- **The Russian Nexus:** Senate Intelligence Committee reports and whistleblower testimony confirm that CA's parent company, SCL Group, briefed Russian entities on these methodologies. CA executives had links to Russian state firms (e.g., Lukoil) and sought to share research on "election disruption strategies". ³⁵
- **Psychographic Methodology:** The core innovation was using the "Big Five" personality traits (Openness, Conscientiousness, Extroversion, Agreeableness, Neuroticism) to craft messages.
 - *Application:* Fear-based messages for neurotic users; tradition-based messages

for conscientious users. Russia has since industrialized this manual process using AI, allowing for "micro-targeting" at a scale CA could only imagine.³⁸

4.2 "Portal Kombat": The Automation of Disinformation

In 2024, the French agency VIGINUM exposed a massive Russian network dubbed "Portal Kombat."

- **Anatomy of the Network:** The network consists of at least 193 "news portals" (e.g., *pravda-fr.com*, *pravda-en.com*, *pravda-pl.com*) managed by a Crimea-based web development company, **TigerWeb**.³⁹
- **TigerWeb & Yevgeny Shevchenko:** The network is technically administered by Yevgeny Shevchenko. It utilizes massive automation to scrape pro-Russian content from Telegram channels, translate it using AI, and republish it across the portal network.⁴¹
- **Strategic Effect:** This creates an "information flood." The localized domains (*.fr*, *.en*) lend a veneer of legitimacy, while the sheer volume of content ("saturation") manipulates search engine algorithms, ensuring pro-Russian narratives appear in top results for users in France, the UK, and the US.¹⁰

4.3 The "African Initiative": Successor to Wagner

Following the dissolution of the Wagner Group's propaganda arm, the "African Initiative" (AI) emerged as the primary vehicle for Russian influence in Africa.

- **Structure:** AI is a "news agency" run by Artem Kureyev (linked to the FSB) and supported by the GRU. It operates physical bureaus in Burkina Faso and Mali, combining digital propaganda with on-the-ground mobilization.⁴²
- **The "African Kalashnikov" Node:** A key asset is the Telegram channel "African Kalashnikov," which disseminates radical anti-Western content. It serves as a source node for the wider ecosystem of pro-Russian influencers in the Sahel.⁴⁴

4.4 Anglophone vs. Francophone Targeting Strategies

Russia tailors its cognitive warfare narratives to the specific cultural and historical vulnerabilities of the target sphere.

The Francophone Strategy (Sahel & Overseas Territories)

- **Narrative: "Neo-Colonial Liberation."** Russia positions itself as the successor to the Soviet Union's anti-colonial legacy. France is depicted as the eternal exploiter ("Françafrique"), and local juntas are framed as "second independence" fighters.
- **Tactics:**
 - **Physical-Digital Blending:** AI organizes rallies where protesters wave Russian flags. Images of these rallies are then amplified globally by "Portal Kombat" sites to prove "organic support."
 - **New Caledonia:** During the 2024 riots, the **Baku Initiative Group** (an Azerbaijani state proxy aligned with Russia) coordinated with Russian networks to spread disinformation. Hashtags like #FrenchColonialism were boosted, and fake images

of French police atrocities were circulated to incite violence.⁴⁵

The Anglophone Strategy (West Africa & Commonwealth)

- **Narrative: "Traditional Values vs. Western Decadence."** In Anglophone Africa (Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda), the anti-colonial narrative is less effective due to the different nature of British decolonization. Instead, Russia pivots to a "Culture War" narrative.
 - **Themes:** The West is portrayed as imposing "LGBTQ+ ideology" and eroding traditional African family values. Russia is presented as the defender of religious and moral tradition.
- **Health Disinformation:** A major campaign in 2024–2025 targeted US-funded health initiatives (PEPFAR, malaria programs). The African Initiative spread conspiracies that Western pharmaceutical companies were testing biological weapons or spreading viruses—a direct revival of the Soviet "Operation Infektion" (AIDS disinformation) tactics.⁴³

5. Comparative Influence & Institutional Response

The capability gap between the West and Russia in the cognitive domain is widening, driven by divergent institutional trajectories.

5.1 The Collapse of the US Global Engagement Center (GEC)

The US Global Engagement Center was the primary interagency body for coordinating counter-disinformation.

- **The Shutdown:** In December 2024, the GEC's authorization expired. Its functions were briefly transferred to a "Counter Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference" (R/FIMI) hub.
- **Political Demise:** In April 2025, Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced the permanent closure of R/FIMI, citing concerns that the office had been used to "censor American voices".⁴⁸
- **Strategic Vacuum:** This decision dismantled the centralized "brain" of US counter-propaganda efforts. The successor arrangement disperses responsibility to regional bureaus, leading to fragmentation. At the exact moment Russia centralized its influence operations under the African Initiative and Portal Kombat, the US fired its primary experts and dissolved its coordinating body.⁵⁰

5.2 France's Proactive Defense: VIGINUM

In stark contrast, France has institutionalized a proactive defense.

- **VIGINUM:** Created in 2021, VIGINUM is a technical service dedicated to detecting foreign digital interference. Unlike the GEC, which faced domestic political headwinds, VIGINUM has a clear mandate focused on *foreign* actors.
- **Lutte Informatique d'Influence (L2I):** The French military doctrine of "Military Influence Operations" allows for offensive maneuvers in the information space to

deceive adversaries and degrade their propaganda capabilities. This "naming and shaming" approach (e.g., publicly exposing the Portal Kombat network) is more aggressive than the US or UK approach.³²

5.3 NATO and the UK

- **UK:** The UK relies on the **Atlantic Bastion** for physical defense and units like **77 Brigade** for information operations. However, the UK lacks a centralized civilian agency comparable to VIGINUM, often relying on GCHQ and the Foreign Office for attribution.
 - **NATO:** The Alliance has established the **Cognitive Warfare** concept as a domain of operations. The **Applied Cognitive Effects (ACE)** team at NATO ACT is developing doctrine to "inoculate" populations against disinformation, viewing it as a resilience issue rather than just a communication issue.⁷
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6. Case Studies in Hybrid Convergence

6.1 The British Isles: The "Bastion" Under Siege

The convergence of physical and cognitive threats is acute in the British Isles.

- **Physical:** The *Yantar's* mapping of Irish Sea cables threatens the UK's economic lifeline.
- **Cognitive:** Simultaneously, Russian bot networks exploit UK domestic issues (cost of living, immigration) to erode trust in the government's ability to provide security. The laser incident with the RAF was spun by Russian diplomats as British "hysteria," a narrative immediately amplified by automated accounts to weaken public support for defense spending.¹⁵

6.2 The Sahel and West Africa: The Cognitive Coup

In the Sahel, Russia proved that cognitive warfare can yield physical territory.

- **Mechanism:** The "African Initiative" flooded the information space with anti-French narratives for years. This created the political conditions for military coups in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger.
- **Result:** The expulsion of French troops and the arrival of the Russian "Africa Corps" (formerly Wagner). This was a "cognitive coup" that preceded the physical shift in power.⁴⁴

6.3 New Caledonia: The Vulnerability of the Periphery

The May 2024 riots in New Caledonia serve as a warning for the future.

- **Convergence:** The physical isolation of the territory (dependent on underwater cables) combined with a foreign-backed cognitive assault (Azerbaijan/Russia disinformation) to create a crisis of sovereignty. The "Baku Initiative Group" acted as a force multiplier for local grievances, demonstrating how Russia uses "franchise" partners to attack Western interests in the Indo-Pacific.⁴⁵

7. Conclusions and Strategic Outlook

As of 2026, the Russian Federation has successfully operationalized a **Hybrid Trident** capability that threatens the Anglophone and Francophone worlds on physical, logical, and cognitive levels.

Key Findings:

1. **The Seabed is the New Frontline:** The *Yantar* and the "Great African Expedition" vessels are not merely researching; they are preparing the battlefield. The bathymetric mapping of cable routes in the Atlantic and Indian Oceans provides Russia with a "kill switch" option for the global economy. The UK's "Atlantic Bastion" is a necessary recognition of this reality.
2. **Cognitive Warfare has Scaled and Automated:** The move from manual troll farms to the automated "Portal Kombat" and "African Initiative" networks allows Russia to attack Francophone and Anglophone information environments simultaneously. The targeting has moved from political polarization to inducing social unrest and health crises.
3. **Asymmetry in Institutional Defense:** A dangerous gap has opened between the US and France. While France has centralized its response under VIGINUM and adopted offensive doctrines, the US has unilaterally disarmed its primary counter-disinformation body (GEC). This leaves the Anglophone world, particularly in the Global South, vulnerable to unchecked Russian narratives.
4. **The Francophone "Soft Underbelly":** Russia has identified the French overseas territories and the Sahel as the most vulnerable flank of the West. By leveraging anti-colonial grievances and physical proximity (via maritime assets in the Indian Ocean), they are successfully eroding French sovereignty.

Strategic Implication:

The correlation between a Russian research ship mapping a cable off Reunion Island and a bot farm spreading anti-French disinformation in Paris is not coincidental; it is doctrinal. It represents a coordinated effort to stress-test the connective tissue of the Western alliance. The "Hybrid Trident" is designed to exploit the seams between physical security and cognitive resilience. Without a reintegration of Western capabilities—combining naval vigilance with a renewed, coordinated cognitive defense—the integrity of the democratic world's connection to reality remains at acute risk.

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